

West Coast Conference Lay Organization

Constitution and By-Laws



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Conference President**

**The Constitution and By-Laws of the West Coast
Conference
Lay Organization of the Eleventh Episcopal District
of the
African Methodist Episcopal Church**

**The West Coast Conference
of the
Eleventh Episcopal District Lay Organization
of the
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Constitution and By-Laws

ARTICLE I – Name

Section 1. The name of this organization shall be the West Coast Conference of the Eleventh Episcopal District Lay Organization of the African Methodist Episcopal Church.

ARTICLE II –Mission, Statement, Purpose and Objectives

Section 1. Mission Statement – The Lay Organization of the African Methodist Episcopal Church is commissioned to teach, train and empower its members for lay ministry, global leadership and service following the tenets of Jesus Christ.

Section 2. Purpose – To organize and train the laity of the African Methodist Episcopal Church so that lay persons may maximally utilize their God-given abilities and skills to improve and extend the kingdom to create happiness, peace, and harmony among its members.

Section 3. Objectives – To accomplish this purpose, the following objectives are adopted and promoted for the West Coast Conference Lay Organization:

- a. To instill in the membership of the church a love for, and an appreciation of the history, traditions, principles and development of African Methodism by encouraging, motivating, and educating all lay persons.
- b. To keep forever alive the sacred memory of Richard Allen, the illustrious founder of the AMEC.
- c. To advocate respect and loyalty at all times to constituted authority and leadership.
- d. To encourage the laity to support the total program of the church in the local congregation, in the community, and throughout the Connection.
- e. To foster a systematic and regular study of The Book of Discipline of the African Methodist Episcopal Church and parliamentary procedure, to the end that greater knowledge and information may be disseminated among the laity, and with the further purpose of encouraging lay members to participate more largely in the general functioning and supervision of the African Methodist Episcopal Church.
- f. To foster, influence, and support all constructive and progressive legislation for the church that promotes the teachings of Jesus Christ.
- g. To encourage development, recognition, and utilization of the most appropriate operational practices and modern technology in conducting the activities of the African Methodist Episcopal Church.
- h. To promote the spread of personal evangelism through activities designed to prepare lay members for appropriately conveying God's Word.

- h. To provide training in Christian stewardship, which causes lay members to recognize that the connotation of stewardship addresses more than giving money.
- i. To increase the circulation of church periodicals.
- j. To provide for the orderly and systematic training of lay persons, especially officers, in order that they might more effectively perform their service responsibilities.
- k. To promote activities that will result in harmonious fellowship for lay persons throughout the Connection.
- l. To help in the support of the AME educational institutions.
- m. To give financial assistance to the Connectional Lay Economic Development Corporation/Episcopal District Lay Economic Development Corporation (CLEDC/EDLEDC) in support of Connectional programs and Episcopal District programs.

ARTICLE III - Divisions

Section 1. The West Coast Lay Organization shall be composed of three (3) Districts of the Annual Conference (Lakeland District, St. Petersburg District, and the Tampa District) all local organizations of a Station or Circuit. The divisions shall mirror the responsibilities of the Episcopal Organization.

ARTICLE IV - Membership

Section 1. Membership in this organization is open to all Lay (un-ordained) members of the African Methodist Episcopal Church, in good and regular standing, in their Local, District of the Annual Conference, Conference. Good and regular standing is defined as every member being governed by the Constitution of the Lay Organization, pays required dues as set by his/her local Lay Organization, attends fifty percent (50%) of the Local Lay Organization meetings and participates at the Districts of the Annual Conference Lay Organization and the West Coast Conference Lay Organization

Section 2. Districts of the Annual Conference – The Districts of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall be composed of:

- a. All elected officers of the Westcoast Conference Lay Organization as well as any elected officers of the Eleventh Episcopal District Lay Organization who is a member of a local church of the Westcoast Conference.
- b. All Presidents, Directors of Lay Activities of the Districts of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations and Young Adult Representatives.
- c. Six (6) elected delegates from each Districts of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations, at least one of whom shall be a young adult, ages 18-35.
- d. Each President and six (6) elected delegates, at least one of whom shall be a young adult, ages 18-35, of each organized Station or Circuit Lay Organization of the Annual Conference.
- e. Any elected officers of The Connectional Lay Organization or the Eleventh Episcopal District Lay Organization.

ARTICLE V – Officers, Duties and Responsibilities

Section 1. The elected Officers of The West Coast Conference Lay Organization and its Divisions shall be:

- a. President
 - b. First Vice President
 - c. Second Vice President*
 - d. Third Vice President*
 - e. Recording Secretary
 - f. Assistant Recording Secretary*
 - g. Corresponding Secretary*
 - h. Treasurer
 - i. Financial Secretary*
 - j. Chaplain
 - k. Historiographer*
 - l. Parliamentarian*
 - m. Director of Lay Activities
 - n. Director of Public Relations*
 - o. Young Adult Representative
- (*Elected at discretion of Divisions, see Article III of this Constitution)

a. Duties and Responsibilities. The President of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall:

- 1. Lead with vision and integrity. This includes serving as a spokesperson for laity in the church, a representative for lay ministry in ecumenical and interfaith gatherings or an advocate in public policy arenas.
- 2. Preside over its Conference Convention during regular, special, or emergency meetings, the Executive Board, and all other official meetings of this organization.
- 3. Be the active head of said organization, and shall be responsible for seeing that the Constitution and By-Laws of this organization, as well as the orders and policies of the Executive Board are fully carried out.
- 4. Be responsible for expanding and developing lay work throughout the conference through channels of the District of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations.
- 5. Be responsible for such other duties as may be usual and customary to the position, and which may be assigned from time to time by the Executive Board, and the directives approved by the Episcopal Convention.
- 6. Appoint chairpersons of all Standing, Special, Convention and Ad Hoc Committees.
- 7. Conference President or his or her designee shall preside over all the elections of officers on the District level.

b. Duties and Responsibilities. The First Vice President shall:

- 1. Be responsible for Membership Recruitment, Retention/and Coordinate such duties as

assigned by the President, and

2. Assume the complete duties of the President during an absence or when it has been determined by the Executive Board that the President can no longer perform the duties.

c. Duties and Responsibilities. The Second Vice President shall:

1. Be responsible for Strategic Planning and Coordinate such duties as assigned by the President and the Executive Board.
2. Serve in the absence of the President and First Vice President, preside at the meetings and assume all duties of the President.

d. Duties and Responsibilities. The Third Vice President shall:

1. Coordinate such duties as Personal Evangelism and coordinating those efforts with the appropriate departments, within the church, and in the absence of the President, First Vice President and Second Vice President preside at the meetings and assume all the duties of the office of President.

e. Duties and Responsibilities. The Recording Secretary shall:

1. Serve as Secretary of the Conference and the Conference Executive Board.
2. Be responsible for recording attendance, accurate minutes of all business transacted during meetings, and for reading and distributing minutes of any previous meetings ensuring widespread dissemination of pertinent information.
3. In the absence of the President and Vice Presidents, the Recording Secretary shall preside until a chairperson pro tempore is elected.
4. Prepare, for the presiding officer, a statement of unfinished business to come before the meeting and a report of the Executive Board meetings to be presented at the Conference Convention.
5. Hold the bond of the Treasurer and the Financial Secretary.

f. Duties and Responsibilities. The Assistant Recording Secretary shall:

1. Assist the Recording Secretary in all duties as outlined above.
2. In the absence of the Recording Secretary, shall perform the duties of the Recording Secretary.

g. Duties and Responsibilities. The Corresponding Secretary shall:

1. Ensure lay ministry focus through effective communication. This includes sharing congratulations, well wishes, condolences and other news about laity.
2. Report pertinent information to the Executive Board, and reply to correspondence as directed by the President and/or the Executive Board.
3. Maintain a network of internal communications between the West Coast Conference District Lay Organization and its subordinate bodies.
4. Compose communication as needed and/or directed by the President. Maintain liaison with the Director of Public Relations to ensure publication of pertinent information.

h. Duties and Responsibilities. The Treasurer shall:

1. Serve as a member of the Budget and Stewardship Committee which is responsible for preparation of the organization's budget for the fiscal year.
2. Disbursements of all funds shall be made in accordance with the line item budget approved by the Conference Convention. Expenditures not reflected/listed in the budget must be approved by the President and the Executive Board with appropriate justification.
3. Keep accurate records and give an itemized report at each Executive Board meeting and the Annual Convention.

i. Duties and Responsibilities. The Financial Secretary shall:

1. Maintain an independent set of records of all financial transactions and assist with work in concert with the Treasurer.
2. Serve as a member of the Budget and Stewardship Committee.
3. Receive and record all funds. All funds shall be turned over to the treasurer within a period not to exceed ten (10) days.
4. Write vouchers countersigned by the President that authorize expenditures, pursuant to the approved budget of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization, which are to be paid by the Treasurer.

j. Duties and Responsibilities. The Chaplain shall:

1. Make adequate preparation for each Bible Study and Devotional Service, utilizing creative styles that motivates and draws participants into the worship experience.
2. Provide spiritual leadership to this organization.
3. Maintain effective communication with the Chaplains on the District of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations.

k. Duties and Responsibilities. The Historiographer shall:

1. Be responsible for gathering, assembling, and maintaining a written and pictorial record of the activities and achievements of this organization.
2. Act as custodian for all photographs, citations, awards, trophies, and other mementos of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization.
3. Compile / maintain a written history of this organization and submit it as a report to the Executive Board and the Annual Convention.
4. Maintain an archive of the historical records and other documents of the Organization.

l. Duties and Responsibilities. The Parliamentarian shall:

1. Advise the President or presiding officer concerning questions of parliamentary

procedure.

2. Be seated next to the President at all meetings.
3. Follow the Constitution and By-Laws of this organization, The Book of Discipline of the African Methodist Episcopal Church and Robert's Rules of Order Newly Revised, latest edition, at all meetings.
4. Serve as consultant to the Constitution and By-Laws, Rules and other Committees as needed.

m. Duties and Responsibilities. The Director of Lay Activities shall:

1. Maintain a close working relationship with the President and the Young Adult Representative in the planning, developing and implementing of the complete programmatic thrust of this organization.
2. Plan, design, and direct all educational programs and other activities of this organization at the Conference Convention, including but not limited to Training Institute, Banquets, Luncheons, Scholarships, Awards and Speakers in consultation with the President and approval of the Executive Board.
3. Maintain a working relationship with the District of the Annual Conference Lay Directors.
4. Be responsible for implementing the training program and Course of Study received from the Episcopal Lay Organization Director of Lay Activities.
5. Upon receiving the course of study from the Episcopal Lay Organization Director of Lay Activities, the Conference Director, shall forward immediately the Course of Study to the Districts Directors of Lay Activities.
6. Conference Director of Lay Activities shall forward the Course of Study to the District of the Annual Conference, Directors of Lay Activities. The training program and Course of Study shall reach all the Directors of Lay Activities within thirty (30) days after.
7. A full report of progress made in the implementation of the Course of Study and the work of the Director shall be given at each the Conference Convention and the Executive Board Meeting as outlined in this Constitution Committee.

n. Duties and Responsibilities. The Director of Public Relations shall:

1. Oversee all official publications of the organization.
- 2 Publish quarterly periodicals containing news of general interest to the laity Solicit and edit articles for the publication on topics that will appeal to, inspire and motivate subscribers.
- 3.Oversee the entire publication process, including seeking bids from publishers, and the channeling of information to various media.
- 4.Provide for promotion, circulation, subscription fulfillment, and advertising solicitation.
- 5 Prepare a line item budget for the online publication for submission to the Budget and Stewardship Committee and included in the organization budget.
- 6 Seek to bring about harmony of understanding between the church and public through the channeling of information to various media.

7 Be responsible for all press releases and public relations for and during any Lay Organization meetings.

8 Disseminate news items of interest received from the District Lay Organizations through online and/or multi-media processes.

9 Oversee the Conference Website and any internal or external documents, including all social media networking.

9 Duties and Responsibilities. The Young Adult Representative shall:

1. Be responsible for implementing teaching and training opportunities for Young Adults in conjunction with the Director of Lay Activities, and establishing working relationships with other relevant Young Adult Auxiliaries and Ministries within, and outside the AME Church.

2. Prepare a line item budget to reflect the work of this office for submission to the Budget and Stewardship Committee and included in the organization budget.

3. Advocate for Young Adult concerns to the Conference Organization Executive Board and beyond.

4. Facilitate Lay Organization Young Adult events with approval of the President.

5. Voice the concerns and visions of a new generation of laity, and serve as a Christian mentor to a younger generation of African Methodists.

Section 2. The Annual Audit shall include the records of all officers handling finances of The Conference Lay Organization and shall be conducted by an internal auditing committee. The Committee shall report its finding at the Annual Conference Lay Convention. An External audit conducted by a licensed, bonded and insured CPA firm is required one year prior to a change in the Office of the Treasurer. The finding of this audit is reported to the Annual Conference Lay Convention which will include an annual programmatic report from each office with an operational budget.

ARTICLE VI– NOMINATION and ELECTION PROCEDURES

Section 1. All officers and members of The West Coast Conference Lay Organization and its Divisions shall be members in good and regular standing in their Station or Circuit Organization to participate in elections and voting.

Section 2. Any person seeking an elected office in the West Coast Conference Lay Organization must be a member in “good and regular standing” in the organization and must possess the qualifications required for the position being sought. Any candidate for elected office must have registered and attended at least one (1) Conference Convention as a delegate, within the two (2) year period immediately preceding the election year. Registration shall be confirmed from the official registration records to be provided to the nominating committee upon its request.

Section 3. All persons seeking an elected office must submit a “Letter of Intent” with qualifications signed by the District of the Annual Conference President to the Chairperson of the Nominating Committee. The format for the Letter of Intent will be provided by the

Nominating Committee and must be returned by certified/registered mail and postmarked on or before January 1st of the election year. This deadline date will constitute the close of all nominations submitted to the Nominating Committee. There shall be no nominations from the floor of the Conference Convention.

Section 4. All candidates seeking an elected office must have demonstrated active participation in the , Annual Conference, Districts of the Annual Conference and local church lay organization levels within the three (3) year period preceding the election year.

Section 5. No elected officer shall hold more than two (2) one additional office beyond the Local organization.

Section 6. Members of the Nominating Committee shall be ineligible for nomination by the committee for any elected position to be filled (where applicable on the local level)

Section 7. The Nominating Committee shall consist of six (6) persons appointed by the President with nominees to be confirmed by the Executive Board. The President in selecting committee members shall follow these guidelines:

- a. There shall one person appointed from each District of the Annual Conference.
- b. Appointments shall be sensitive to age diversity, at least one (1) and all persons must have demonstrated experience with the nominating process as outlined in Article V1. Selection of committee members must respect the guidelines that govern the committee's duties and reporting timelines.

Section 8. Duties of the Committee

- a. At least three (3) months prior to the West Coast Convention the committee shall call for nominations through a notice submitted for publication on the West Coast Conference Lay Organization's website, and any other appropriate printed or online communication. Such Notice shall inform members when, how and where nomination forms can be obtained. Nomination forms shall also be sent to the District of the Annual Conference Presidents for distribution to interested persons. The nomination form shall request biographical data and other pertinent information which will aid in the qualifying of candidates. Such forms shall be returned to the chair of the nominating committee by prospective nominees, bearing the signature of the District of the Annual Conference Lay President, no later than December 1st of an election year prior to the convening of the Conference Convention.
- b. The committee shall thoroughly examine any and all necessary information regarding nominees for elected offices being sought. Each nominee must be notified of his/her eligibility which signals authorization to campaign for the designated office. From those persons found qualified for the offices being sought, the committee shall prepare a slate of nominees, listing the qualifications of the nominees for offices to be elected at the West Coast Conference Convention. On or before October 15 or six (6) months prior to the convention,(or which ever comes 1st). the slate will be distributed to the Executive Board of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization for approval prior to being provided to each Districts of the annual Conference

c. No political campaigning for office shall take place before candidates are qualified as nominees by the Nominating Committee. Campaigning is defined as placing ads in Souvenir Journals or any AME Church Publication (where applicable) at any level as a candidate, distributing campaign literature/paraphernalia or visits to formal functions of The West Coast Conference Lay Organization or its subordinate bodies with the expressed purpose of campaigning. Participation in campaign activities prior to being qualified as a nominee will result in valid disqualification for that candidate if confirmed by the Nominating Committee and the Executive Board.

ARTICLE VII– ELECTION OF OFFICERS

Section 1. Officers shall be elected at the West Coast Conference Lay Convention, unless otherwise provided for herein. All elections shall be by secret ballot, electronic or paper, except in the case where the office is not contested. When there is only one candidate for office the chair can take a voice vote or declare that the nominee is elected, effecting the election by unanimous consent or acclamation. A majority vote shall be necessary to elect. Elected officers shall assume office immediately upon installation. There should be a ceremony for the Installation of Officers prior to the close of the West Coast Convention. This shall be the final order of business at the closing Conference Convention. The candidate seeking elected office does not have to be present to be voted upon. Any method of election in any division other than by secret ballot, except in the case of uncontested offices, shall be declared null and void by the West Coast Conference Lay Organization.

Section 2. The West Coast Conference Lay Officers shall be elected to a two (2) year term at the West Coast Annual Lay Convention.

Section 3. Term Limitation. The elected officers of West Coast Conference Lay Organization and its Divisions shall serve no more than eight (8) consecutive years in the same office.

Section 4. If an officer completes a term of office which was vacated by the incumbent due to death, illness, resignation, and/or other conditions approved by the Executive Board, the unexpired portion of the term, will not count as a full term for the purposes of term limitation.

Section 5. Transition Period. A transitional period of sixty (60) days beginning at the close of the Conference Convention is provided for outgoing officers to reconcile files, records, and make inventories before transferring them to the incoming officers. Outgoing officers shall complete the transfer of all files, records, books, papers and property belonging to the organization to the incoming officers on or before the end of the sixty-day period

Section 6. Vacancy in the Office of President and/ or vice presidents If a vacancy occurs in the office of President due to death, resignation, disability or temporary inability or other causes, the First Vice President shall immediately assume the Office of President, for the unexpired term of office; the Second Vice President shall ascend to the Office of First Vice President, and the third Vice President becomes second Vice President, leaving the vacancy to be filled in the office of the lowest ranking Vice President. If the position was contested during election for the office of Third Vice President, the person with the second highest

number of votes will immediately fill the position of Third Vice President. If the position was uncontested, the president shall, with the confirmation of the Executive Board appoint an active member, possessing qualifications for the office of the third vice president, to fill the vacancy, if the remainder of the term is less than one (1) year. A majority vote by the Executive Board shall determine the result. If the remainder of the term of office for The Third Vice President is greater than one (1) year, a special election shall be held by the Executive Board within forty- five (45) days, of the vacancy date, to fill this position. The Letter of Intent shall be sent from the person who last served as Chairperson of the Nominating Committee to each person who wishes to be a candidate for the office of third vice president. Nominating procedures, approved for last West Coast Conference Lay election, will be used for the election. All voting shall be by secret ballot (electronic or paper). Any person appointed and/or elected to fill an unexpired term of President shall subsequently be eligible to be elected to four (4) full two (2) year terms in accordance with this constitution and By-Laws.

Section 7. Vacancy of Elected Officer other than President and/ or vice presidents. If a vacancy occurs in an elected officer's position, other than that of a President, due to death, resignation, disability or inability to serve, the President shall, with the confirmation of the Executive Board, appoint an active member, possessing qualifications for the office, to fill the vacancy if the remainder of the term is less than one (1) year. A majority vote by the Executive Board shall determine the result. If the remainder of the term of office is greater than one (1) year, a special election shall be held by the Executive Board within forty-five (45) days, of the vacancy date, to fill this position. The Letter of Intent shall be sent from the person who last served as Chairperson of the Nominating Committee to each person who wishes to be a candidate for the vacant office. Nominating procedures, approved for last Conference Lay election, will be used for the election. All voting shall be by secret ballot, electronic or paper. Any person appointed and/ or elected to fill an unexpired term of office shall subsequently be eligible to be elected to 2 full four (4) year terms in accordance with this Constitution and By-Laws.

Section 8. Removal of Elected Officer. The Organizational and Officers Effectiveness Committee/shall give its findings annually. Any elected officer, not performing his/her duties, as outlined in this Constitution and By-Laws, shall be notified in writing by the President, of his/her failure to perform designated duties, with a copy forwarded to the Chair, Organizational and Officers Effectiveness Committee, and the Executive Board. If failure to perform his/her duties continues for a period of ninety (90) days after notification, the matter will be referred to the Executive Board for action. If the President is not performing his/her duties, as outlined in this Constitution and By-Laws, as deemed by a majority vote of the Executive Board, he/she shall be notified in writing by the Executive Board through the Corresponding Secretary of his/her failure to perform designated duties. The Executive Board, may, in the interim of the Conference Convention suspend the elected officer. The final decision to expel or reinstate from/to office shall rest exclusively with the West Coast Conference Lay Organization in its Conference Convention. The Organizational and Officers Effectiveness Committee/ will give guidelines, implementation and corrective actions when deemed necessary.

Section 9. West Coast Conference Lay Organization Officers shall be elected biennially.

Section 10. Districts of the Annual Conference Lay Organization Officers shall be elected

biennially.

Section 11. Station or Circuit Lay Organization Officers shall be elected annually

ARTICLE VIII—Qualifications

Each officer shall be responsible for understanding and fulfilling his/her duties and those officers with a budget shall prepare and submit an annual line item budget to the Budget and Stewardship Committee, to be included in the Annual Budget for approval by the Conference Convention.

Section 1. The President

a. Qualifications. The President of The West Coast Lay Organization shall have a commitment to lay ministry as demonstrated by:

1. Prior service as either an elected officer of the Episcopal District, Conference, Districts of the Annual Conference or local church Organization.

Section 2. First Vice President

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the position of First Vice President must possess the same qualifications as provided for the President.

Section 3. Second Vice President

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the position of Second Vice President must possess the same qualifications as provided for the President

Section 4. Third Vice President

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the position of Third Vice President must possess the same qualifications as provided for the President.

Section 5. Recording Secretary

a. Qualifications. Any candidates seeking the office of Recording Secretary must possess:

1. Proficiency in writing and composition of the English language, basic reading competency, editing and record keeping skills.
2. Prior secretarial experience or training.
3. Ability to prepare and present minutes and reports.

Section 6. Assistant Recording Secretary

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the position of Assistant Recording Secretary must

possess the same qualifications as required for the Recording Secretary.

Section 7. Corresponding Secretary

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the position of Corresponding Secretary must possess the same qualifications as required for the Recording Secretary.

Section 8. Treasurer

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the office of Treasurer must demonstrate:

1. Experience in financial management, including but not limited to, the areas of accounting, bookkeeping, and finance, preferably in non-profit organizations. .
2. Ability to be bonded
3. Experience and knowledge with computerized financial or accounting software and financial accounting/reporting.

Section 9. Financial Secretary

- a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the office of Financial Secretary must possess the same qualifications as those of the Treasurer.
- b. of Financial Secretary must possess the same qualifications as those of the Treasurer.

Section 10. Chaplain

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the position of Chaplain must demonstrate:

1. A Christian commitment, possess a high level of spiritual maturity, effective interpersonal and communication skills.
2. Training and experience in Christian Education.
3. Knowledge of the Bible and the AMEC Hymnal.
4. Experience in preparing and conducting Bible study and worship.

Section 11. Historiographer

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the office of Historiographer must demonstrate:

1. Prior experience with emphasis in research, writing, and publishing historical information.
2. Proficiency in English is required.
- 3 Ability to use technology (electronic media, including video, photos, and other graphics) for data gathering, organizing, record keeping and writing.
4. Knowledge of record and artifact preservation specific to an organization's founding, operations, projects, and other activities.

Section 12. Parliamentarian

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the office of Parliamentarian must demonstrate:

1. They are a registered Parliamentarian in good and regular standing of the National Association of Parliamentarians or an equivalent certification where one exists. If a registered Parliamentarian is not available the candidate must demonstrate a working knowledge of Parliamentary Law and have served on other levels of the church for two or more year in that capacity.

Section 13. Director of Lay Activities

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the office of Director of Lay Activities must demonstrate:

1. Extensive experience in research, speech, writing and proficiency in the English language, program planning, development, designing, implementation, teaching, training, adult learning, and/or administration, and technology (electronic media, including video, photos, and other graphics) for data gathering, organizing, record keeping and writing.

Section 14. Director of Public Relations

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the office of Director of Public Relations must demonstrate:

1. A working knowledge of media relations, marketing, sales, prior experience in preparing and distributing press releases.
2. Strong communication skills and extensive experience in English, speech, and journalism.

Section 15. Young Adult Representative

a. Qualifications. Any candidate seeking the office of Young Adult Representative shall:

1. Be between the ages of 18-35 at the time of election. Completion of high school and pursuing a post-secondary degree (at the optimum) is required.
2. Demonstrate visionary leadership skills through work experience or volunteer opportunities, especially with Youth and Young Adults within the church or other organizations.
3. Possess strong abilities to provide training, and demonstrate effective communication skills.
4. Maintain a working relationship with the Director of Lay Activities

ARTICLE IX EXECUTIVE BOARD

Section 1. There shall be an Executive Board of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization, composed of the elected officers of the organization, the President of the District of the Annual Conference and chairpersons of standing committees.

Section 2. The Executive Board shall meet at least twice annually, at the time and place designated by the President and members of the Executive Board. The Board shall hold two (2) meeting, immediately preceding and at the seat of, the West Coast Conference Convention.

Section 3. Teleconference Meetings may be held to address specific matters of concern. Notice of the call with a proposed agenda must be issued to members of the Executive Board no later than three (3) days prior to the call. Vacancies of officers may not be filled via teleconference call. (Article VII, section 1)

Section 4. The President of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall preside over the meetings of the Executive Board, and the Recording Secretary shall serve as secretary of the Executive Board.

Section 5. The Executive Board shall have the authority to carry on the work of West Coast Conference Lay Organization during the interim of the West Coast Conference Convention.

Section 6. The Executive Board shall establish the rules and regulations by which it shall be governed. The Board shall have power over the supervision and direction of all affairs of the Organization during the interim of the West Coast Convention of West Coast Conference Lay Organization, except that it shall not infringe upon any of the expressed constitutional provisions herein set forth and provided. Further, The West Coast Conference Lay Organization, in its Conference Convention, may nullify, abrogate, or rescind any action of the Executive Board.

Section 7. The Executive Board shall have such other authority as may be necessary to carry out the general purposes and intent of this Constitution.

Section 8. The Executive Board may establish an Advisory Council to act in a purely advisory capacity. The Advisory Council may consist of past presidents of the Districts of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations and such other distinguished lay members as the President may designate. The Advisory Council shall not exceed five (5) persons.

ARTICLE X – MEETING

Section 1. The West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall meet quarterly in its regular session.

Section 2. The Annual Session of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall be held within the period of the month of March, with the Opening Worship Service being held on Friday. The business session will begin on Saturday. The site of the next West Coast Convention shall be determined one (1) year in advance.

Section 3. The West Coast Conference President and/or a majority of the voting members of the Executive Board may call an emergency meeting of West Coast Conference Lay Organization when such a meeting is deemed necessary. The time, place, and object of such Special or Emergency Meeting shall be clearly set forth in the official call or notice. Only those matters expressly set out in the notice or call shall be deliberated upon, provided however, that no election of officers shall take place at a special or emergency meeting.

Section 4. All delegates to the West Coast Convention must be elected at a regular or properly convened meeting. The names and addresses of all delegates must be submitted to the Conference Convention Registrar on or before March 1st of the West Coast Convention. These names shall be forwarded to the Convention Registrar for the expressed purpose of expediting pre-registration for Educational sessions.

ARTICLE XI –VOTING PRIVILEGES

Section 1. Voting privileges in The West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall be confined and restricted to persons set out under Article IV of this Constitution.

Section 2. No person shall be entitled to more than one (1) vote on an issue or matter in The West Coast Conference Lay Organization, and must be personally present to exercise such privilege. No proxy or absentee voting shall be permitted.

Section 3. Unless otherwise indicated, the majority vote shall prevail in determining all matters.

ARTICLE XII – POWERS AND JURISDICTIONS

Section 1. The West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall exercise prudent and appropriate authority, power, and supervision over all Districts of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations established under the provisions of this Constitution.

ARTICLE XIII – RESERVED AND IMPLIED POWERS

Section 1. Each District of the Annual Conference and Station or Circuit Lay Organizations shall be vested with the full authority to make its own Constitution and By- laws, Rules and Regulations, as may be deemed necessary for proper and orderly conduct of its affairs and for the governing of its officers and members. Each Divisions Constitution shall conform to, and harmonize with the Connectional Constitution and By-laws. Each of these organizations shall have the authority to establish its own Executive Board, raise funds, and in general perform all duties incident to its existence as an autonomous body except, however, said organization shall not make Constitutions and By laws, or Rules and Regulations which are in conflict with, or abridge any part of the Constitution and By-laws of The West Coast Conference Lay Organization or the template for subordinate divisions.

Section 2. A copy of the Constitution and By-laws of each District Lay Organization must be filed with the Constitution and By Laws Committee of The West Coast Conference Lay

Organization for examination and response.

Section 3. Each Districts of the Annual Conference, and each Station or Circuit Lay Organization shall have the following inserted in its Constitution and By-laws: “This Organization shall be subject to and governed by the Constitution and By-laws of The West Coast Conference Lay Organization of the African Methodist Episcopal Church.”

Section 4. **This organization** and each of its Divisions shall at all times be governed by the Constitution and By-Laws of the **Connectional** Lay Organization of the African Methodist Episcopal Church, The Current Book of Discipline, Laws, Doctrines, and Tenets of the African Methodist Episcopal Church and Robert’s Rules of Order, Newly Revised edition.

ARTICLE XIV – COMMITTEES

To ensure successful and effective implementation of programs and projects of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization, other than specified duties of elected officers per Constitution and By-Laws, all Chairpersons shall be appointed by the President.

SECTION 1 Four (4) types of Committees shall exist in the West Coast Conference Lay organization: Standing, Special, Convention and Ah Hoc Committees.

SECTION 2 Standing Committees are appointed to implement specific goals, objectives, and programs that advance of, and are vital to the functioning of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization. Each standing committee shall have no more than six (6) members appointed by the President and approved by the Executive Board. The President in appointing committee members shall follow these guidelines: a) there shall be no more than one person appointed from an Annual Conference Lay Organization, and b) appointments shall be sensitive to age diversity, at least one (1) person between the ages of 18-35, c) all persons must have demonstrated diversity of experiences in the work assigned to the committee’s duties and reporting timeline. The Standing Committees of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall be as follows: Budget and Stewardship, Constitution and By Laws, Organizational and Officers Effectiveness Committees, Scholarship and Awards Committees and other committees deemed as necessary to function by the President and Executive Board.

SECTION 3 Special Committees shall be the following: Nominating, Elections, Auditing and other such committees that are appointed to perform a task that does not fall within the assigned function of a Standing Committee.

SECTION 4 Convention Committees of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall be assigned under the following Commissions: Statistics and Finance, Organization and Structure, Personnel and Procedure, and Program and Activities. The duties and responsibilities of the Commissions shall be included in the Annual Convention guide.

SECTION 5 The credential Committee prepares and presents to the West Coast Conference Lay Convention a certified list of registered officers and delegates that make up the voting strength of the convention.

SECTION 6 The rules committee provides official guidelines of operating procedures specially required for operation of the convening Annual Convention.

SECTION 7 The Budget and Stewardship Committee of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall submit its final report to the regular session of the organization no later than the evening of the second business day of the Annual Convention.

SECTION 8 The Budget and Stewardship Committee is composed of the treasurer, financial secretary, and other members for a total of no more than eight (8), these members shall be appointed by the President. It shall be the duty of this committee to prepare a two (2) year budget, to be submitted to the President and the Executive Board for approval and the Annual Lay Convention for adoption by a majority vote.

SECTION 9 The Constitution and By Laws Committee defines the primary characteristics of the organization, prescribes how the organization functions including all rules that the organization considers so important that they cannot be changed without previous notice to the membership and a two-thirds (2/3) majority vote of the Annual Lay Convention.

Section 10 The Organizational and Officers Effectiveness Committee shall report annually to the Executive Board. The committee will propose and present for the Executive Board the process and tools for the officers evaluation and implement the process. The President has thirty (30) days after the close of the Annual Convention to appoint the Committee Members who will present their findings.

SECTION 11 Ad Hoc Committee is appointed as the need arises to carry out a specific task. It automatically ceases to exist on presentation of its final report to the body.

ARTICLE XV – SUBORDINATE BODIES

Section 1. District of the Annual Conference – The District of the Annual Conference Lay Organizations of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization shall be composed of:

- a. All elected officers.
- b. All Presidents, Directors of Lay Activities of the Districts of the Annual Conference Organizations and Young Adult Representative.
- c. Six (6) elected delegates from each District of the Annual Conference Lay Organization, at least one of whom shall be a young adult, ages 18-35.
- d. Each President and six (6) elected delegates, at least one of whom shall be a young adult, ages 18-35, of each organized Station or Circuit Lay Organization of the Annual Conference.

e. any elected officers of The Connectional Lay Organization or the Eleventh Episcopal Lay Organization

Section 2. District Lay Organizations of the Annual Conference- The District Lay Organization of the Annual Conference shall be composed of

a. all elected officers

b. the president and six (6) elected delegates at least one whom shall be a young adult, ages 18-35 from each station or circuit.

c. any elected officers of the Connectional, Episcopal District or Annual Conference Lay Organizations.

A) This organization is amenable to the Conference Lay Organization and must report to the Conference Lay Organization at least quarterly.

Section 3. Station or Circuit Lay Organization – The pastor of each Station or Circuit shall, within thirty (30) days after the Annual Conference, call a meeting of the members of the Charge for the purpose of organizing a Lay Organization where none exists. The Station or Circuit Lay Organization shall be composed of all members of said Station or Circuit who desire to join. The officers of the organization shall be elected from those enrolled in said organization. The President of the Lay Organization, or a duly elected representative of the local church, becomes a member of the Official Board by virtue of his/her office.

Section 4. The officers of a Station or Circuit Lay Organization shall be those specified in Article V, Section 1 of this Constitution. The Station or Circuit Lay Organization shall fix the time for regular meetings, which should not be fewer than ten (10) times per year.

ARTICLE XVI – AMENDMENTS

Section 1. Amendment of By-Laws. Amendments to the Constitution and By Laws of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization may be made by filing a copy of the proposed amendment with the President, Secretary and Constitution and By-Laws Committee Chair. The Constitution and By-Laws Committee shall ensure that copies of the proposed changes are sent to each conference President at least ninety (90) days prior to the opening of the West Coast Conference Lay Organization Annual Convention. Two-thirds (2/3) vote of the members present and eligible to vote at the Convention shall be required to effect an amendment. Amendments will take effect at the close of the Convention ratifying the Amendments.

Bylaws of The West Coast Conference Lay Organization

The following shall constitute the By Laws of this organization.

Section 1. The Order of Business shall be:

a. Devotion

b. Bible Study

c. Roll Call of Officers

d. Report of Credentials Committee

- e. Registration of Delegates
- f. Reading of Minutes of the Executive Board
- g. Reading of Communications
- h. Reading of Committees Report
- i. President's Message
- j. Reports of Officers
- k. Reports of District Presidents
- l. Unfinished Business
- m. New Business
- n. Report of Committees
- o. Memorial Service
- p. Installation of Officers
- q. Adjournment

Section 2. A majority of delegates present from each District of the Annual Conference Lay Organization with voting delegations at the West Coast Conference Convention shall constitute a quorum for the transaction of all business.

Section 3. The members shall conform to all the rules and regulations of this organization; any member (s) guilty of an infraction or violation of the rules, or for conduct or decorum unbecoming a member, may be removed from membership herein.

Section 4. The order of business herein before outlined may be changed by a two-third (2/3) majority vote of the delegates present at the Conference Convention.

Section 5. All reports of the District of the Annual Conference Presidents and other officers shall be in writing and submitted in triplicate copies, one to be left with the President of the organization, one to be left with the Secretary of the organization, and one to be retained by the officer making the report.

Section 6. Any officer failing to perform his or her official duties shall be accountable to the Executive Board.

Section 7. No officer or any committee shall incur any obligation, which shall be binding, unless such action was authorized in its inception, or subsequently ratified and approved by the organization.

Section 8. The President shall be authorized to appoint and deputize, with sufficient power and authority, as many Marshals as may be deemed necessary to maintain order and decorum in the meeting. It shall be the duty of the Marshals to maintain strict order, see that only members are seated within established bounds of the meeting, and perform such other duties as may be assigned to them by the President in keeping with the duties of their office.

Section 9. Any provision or condition not expressly covered in the Constitution and By-Laws of this Organization shall be interpreted and construed in keeping with the long established

policy, customs, tenets, and traditions of the African Methodist Episcopal Church, The Book of Discipline of the African Methodist Episcopal Church, and Roberts Rules of Order Newly Revised edition.

COLORS

The official colors of The West Coast Conference Lay Organization are: Royal Blue and White or Navy Blue and White.

THE LAY HYMN

Laymen now have thus assembled, In Thy blessed name O God. Guide us in our true endeavor light the pathway that we trod; Give us strength to ever labor for Thy cause Give us strength to ever labor for Thy cause.

We are banded one in union, To fulfill Thy just command. May we be Thy true disciples, Holding to Thy mighty hand; Give us blessings from the fountain of Thy love Give us blessings from the fountain of Thy love.

As we walk this Christian journey, Let us keep our armour bright. Let our works be pure and holy That we stand within Thy sight; Laymen soldiers, strong in unity and love laymen soldiers, strong in unity and love.

May we stand before Thine altar, pledging Lord to work for Thee. In the vineyard, in the pastures Let us Lord Thy pilgrims be; Let us lift the cross forever to the skies, Let us lift the cross forever to the skies.

Tune: (Zion) “Guide Me O Thou Great
Jehovah” written by Frances A. Walston

THE LAY BENEDICTION

“May God bless us with the true spirit of Christianity. That we may live together, not as man over man, but as lay persons working with God. Amen”